Score

Connor Simpson

Solo Baritone Voice and Piano

Mad Song

4'30"

2020

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Mere Fly Press

Mad Song
Solo Baritone Voice and Piano
2022
4’30”
Connor Simpson
Mere Fly Press (ASCAP)

Program Notes

Mad Song uses various extended techniques of the human voice piano and bass drum to create a sonic landscape for William Blake’s *Mad Song*. The sounds of the piece are used to represent Blake’s extensive use of imagery as he contrasts the day from the night.

Mad Song
by William Blake,

The wild winds weep,
And the night is a-cold;
Come hither, Sleep,
And my griefs infold:
But lo! the morning peeps
Over the eastern steeps,
And the rustling birds of dawn
The earth do warn.

Late to the vault
Of paved heaven,
With sorrow fraught
My notes are driven:
They strike the ear of night,
Make weep the eyes of day;
They make mad the roaring winds,
And with tempests play.

Like a fiend in a cloud
With howling woe,
After night I do croud,
And with night will go;
I turn my back to the east,
From whence comforts have increas'd;
For light doth seize my brain
With frantic pain.

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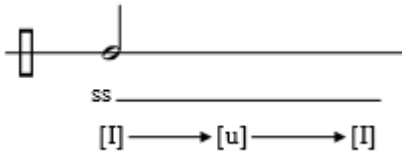
Performance Notes

Voice:



= Transform vowel shape without regard to meter while sustaining hiss. Imitate wind.

Pianist:

A bass drum is to be placed to the left side of the pianist so that they may play the bass drum without standing from their bench.

fingernails across black keys

= Drag a single fingernail back and forth across the black keys of the keyboard. Imitate crackling sounds of foot.

rub bass drum

= Rub bass drum in a circular motion at rapidly varying speeds for given duration. Imitate low roar of wind.

quickly scratch low strings

= Briefly and abruptly scratch low strings of piano with fingernails.

hit bass drum

= Strike bass drum with bass drum mallet without muffling.

forearm slam

= Play chromatic cluster with both forearms in the middle register of the piano.

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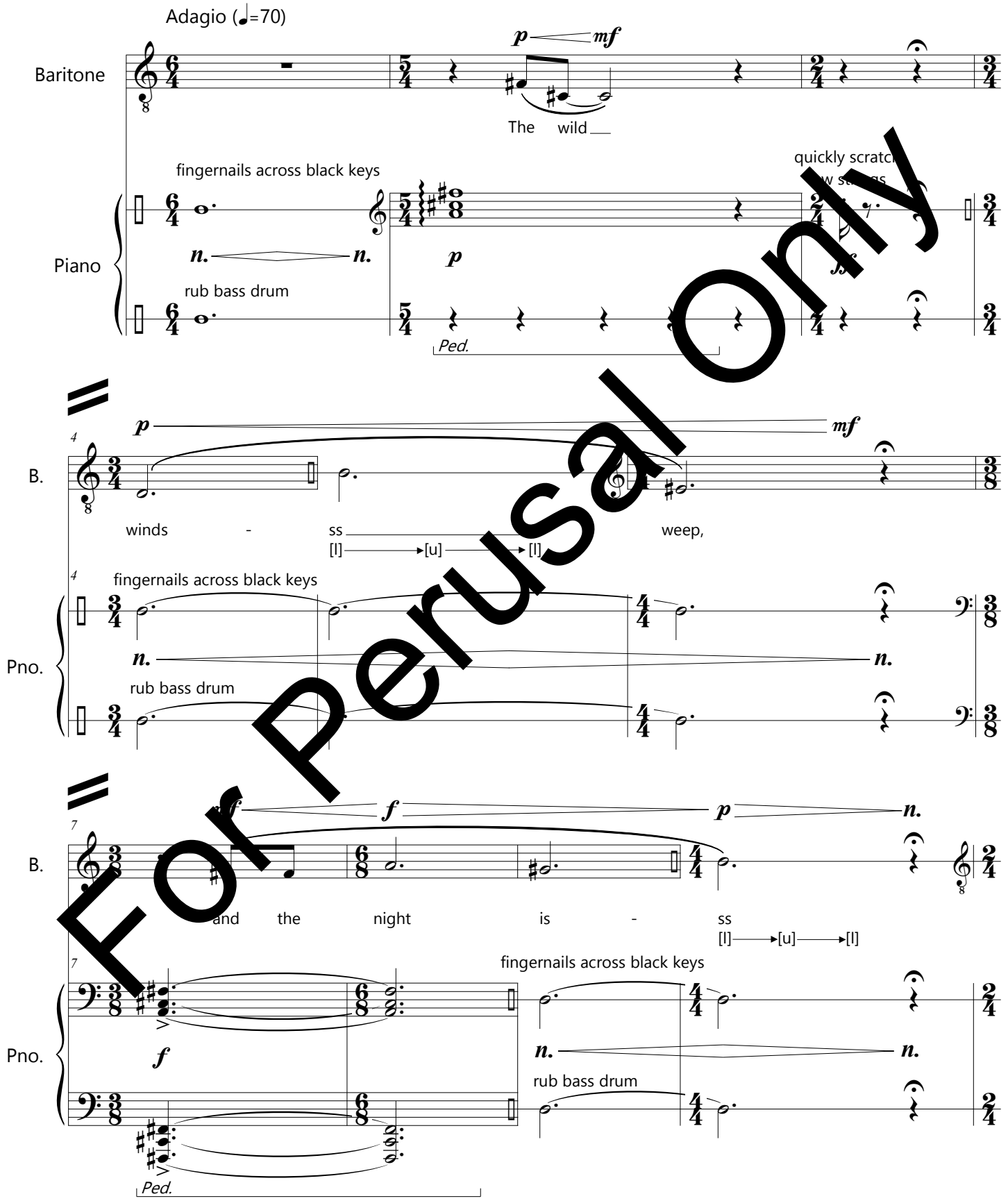
Mad Song

Score

Connor Simpson
Text by William Blake



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11

B.

p mf p ff

a - cold; Come

Pno.

p f ff

Ped. senza Ped.

15

B.

mp n. p

hi - ther, ss - sleep,

[l] → [u]

fingernails across black keys

Pno.

rub bass drum

(Ped.)

18

B.

mf f p n. p

nd my greifs - ss in - fold:

[l] → [u] → [l]

Allegro (♩ = 135)

Pno.

n. pp f

Ped. (Ped.)

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22

B.

f *sub. p*

But lo! the mor - ning peeps

Pno.

(Ped.)

26

B.

f *sub. p* *f*

O-ver ea - stern steeps,

meno mosso (♩ = 85), molto rubato

mf

And the rus-tling birds of dawn

Pno.

(Ped.)

Ped.

30

B.

ff

e earth do scorn.

Allegro (♩ = 135)

mf

sub. p *ff*

Lo! to the vault

Pno.

f

mf

Ped.

Ped.

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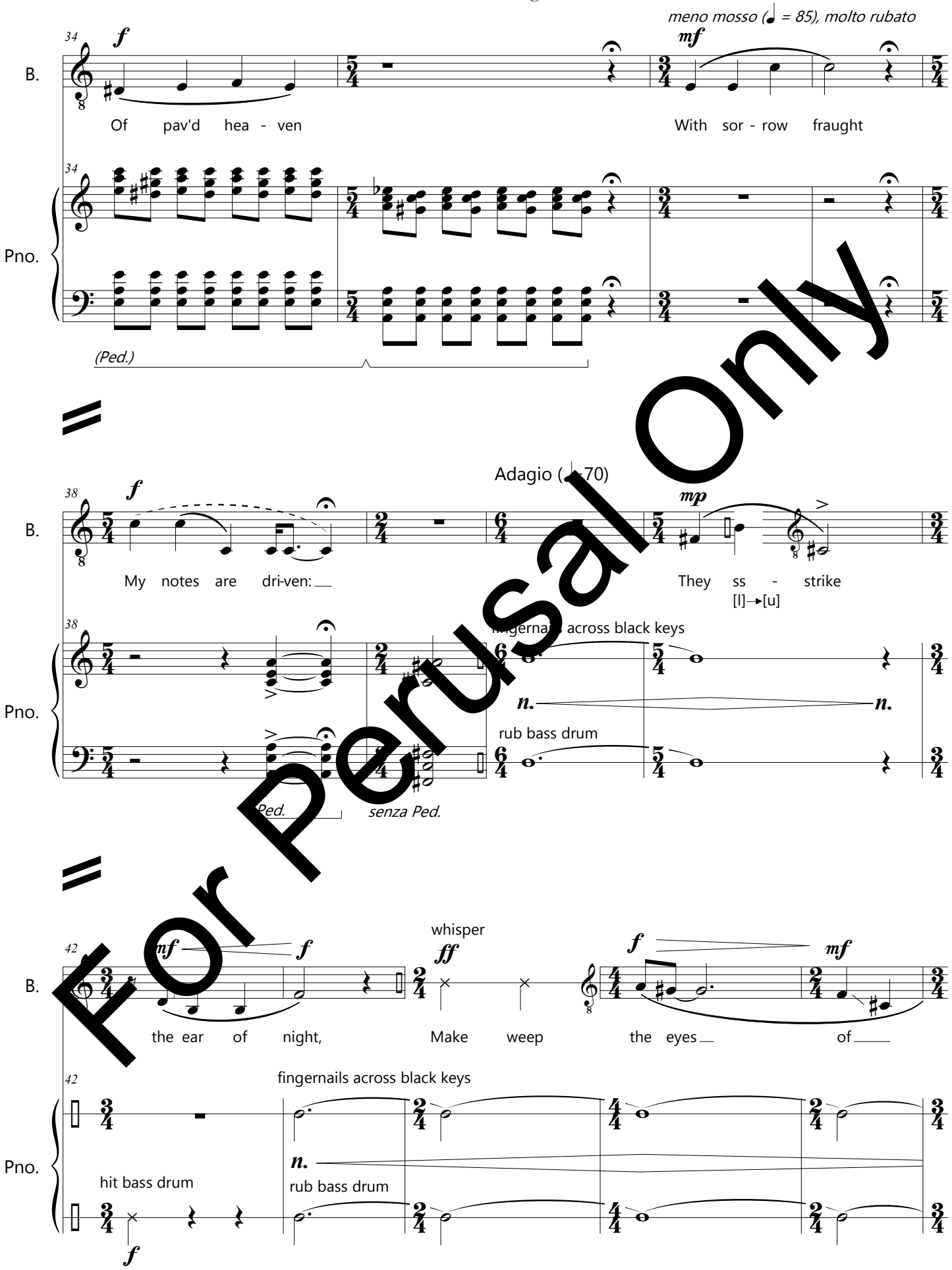

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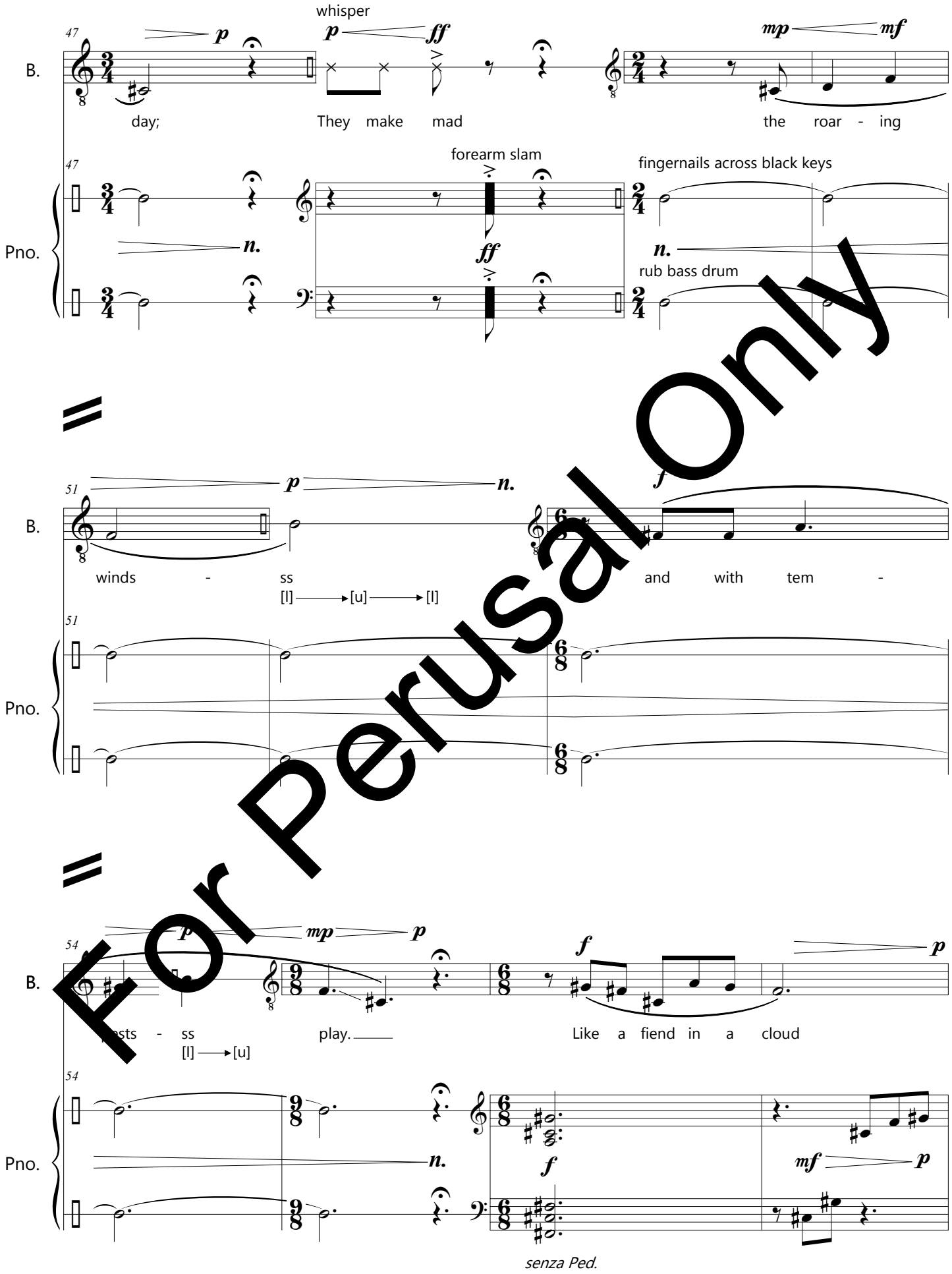

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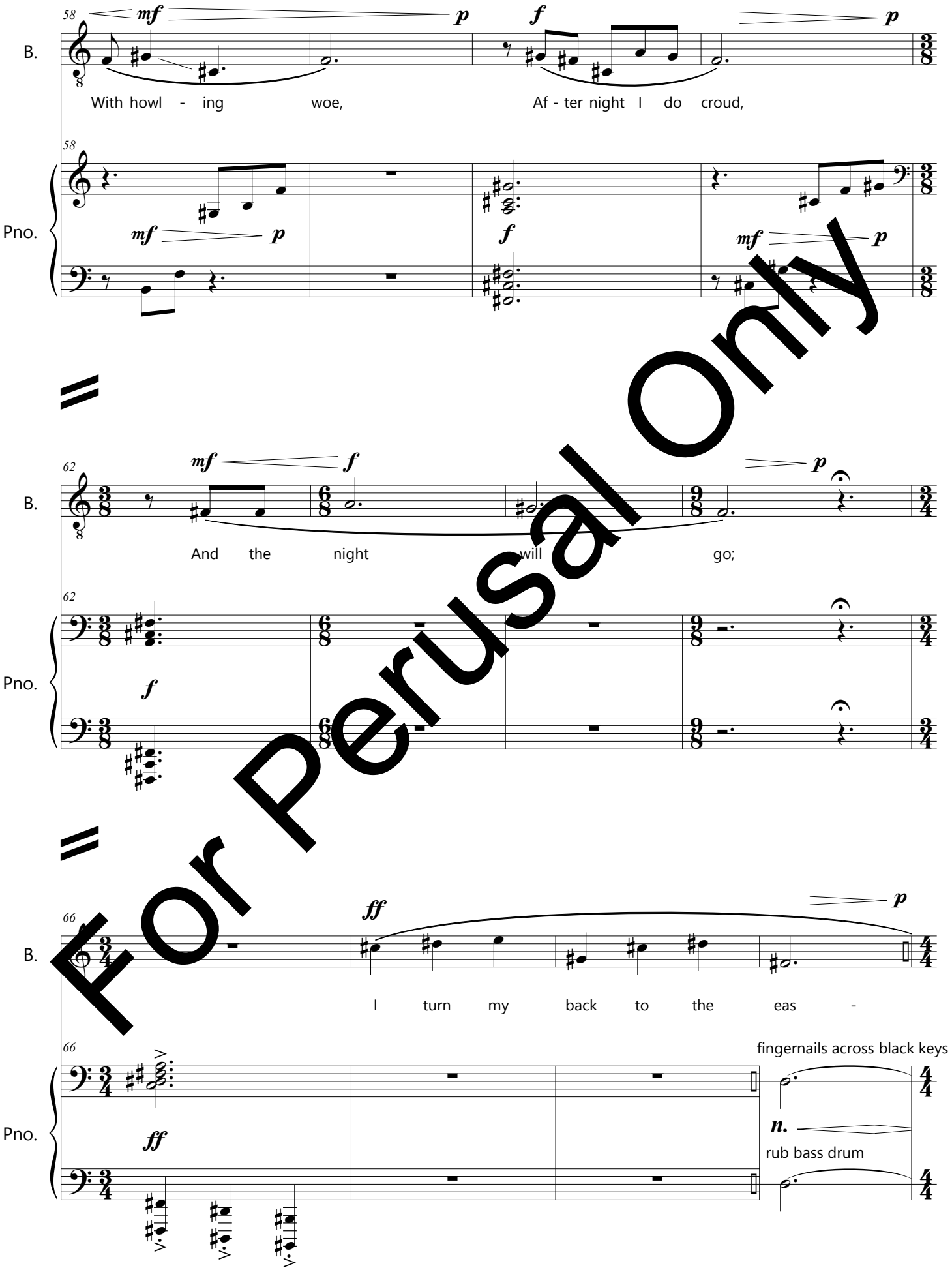

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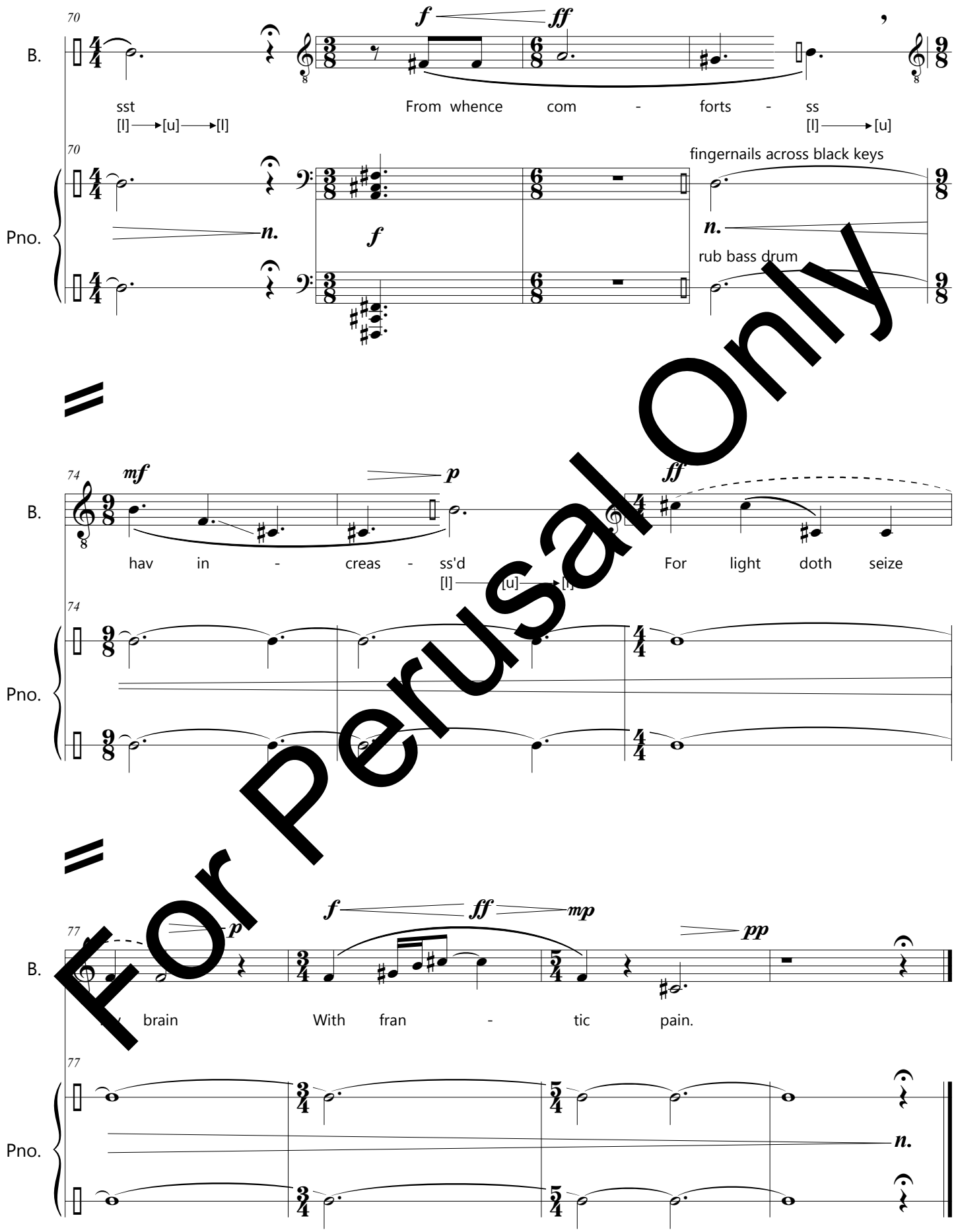

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